

Rwanda

An Africa–Europe Cultural Co-Production · Overview

GOETHE-INSTITUT AFRICA–EUROPE PARTNERSHIPS FOR CULTURE · 2026

Rwanda is internationally legible through two stories — the 1994 genocide and the development ‘miracle’. Both are loud; both crowd out the quieter country. INLAND asks one question across every lead: what survived? What persists in specific families, villages and practices that has been absorbed by neither the colonial inheritance, the Christian mission, nor the modernisation project — and can still be witnessed and photographed today.

We focus on endangered knowledge systems and under-documented living practices surviving despite standardisation, policy change and generational drift. The genocide is context, never the lens; the state is never cast as villain. Every storyline centres a named custodian, a specific place, and a practice that can still be witnessed.

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The 12 Storylines

LOCAL COMMUNITIES

01

What They Carry

Batwa Forest Knowledge

THE STORY

Batwa elders around Musanze hold centuries-deep ecological knowledge of the Nyungwe and Virunga forests — plant identification, animal behaviour, spatial memory — now sought by conservation biologists before it disappears. ~25,000–30,000 Batwa, officially ‘historically marginalised’.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND embeds with elders on a plant walk and records the forest songs — documenting the knowledge itself rather than the (already filmed) displacement. The narrative asks what becomes of forest knowledge when there is no forest left to use it in.

Places: Musanze · Kibingo · forest margins · Sources: AIMPO; INLAND Rwanda research corpus

The Rites That Won't Die

Kubandwa / Ryangombe

THE STORY

A pre-colonial spirit-possession system centred on Ryangombe that missionaries tried to erase, surviving underground in a 92.8% Christian country. A 2021 academic recorded students attending rites 'even in the centre of Kigali'.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND follows the practice through discreet, consent-led fieldwork and academic introductions — documenting an adaptive ritual that crosses linguistic, political and temporal frontiers. If confirmed in the field, the edition's signature story.

Places: Kigali · discreet rural sites · Sources: Pennacini (Turin); Bizimana, RCSP Rwanda 2018

The Hospital Sends You to a Healer

Uburozi and Traditional Medicine

THE STORY

In Kinigi, Musanze — 'the core location for healers' — hospitals refer patients to traditional healers for uburozi, a sorcery/poisoning illness conventional medicine doesn't recognise. ~5,000 healers nationally; a 2022 Traditional Medicine policy exists.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND shadows a referral from clinic to healer and back, with portraits of both — documenting a state-acknowledged parallel healthcare system operating in the open and almost entirely unreported internationally.

Places: Kinigi · Burera · Bushozi · Musenyi · Sources: BMC Compl. Med. & Therapies 2021; Rwanda FDA 2022

Crushed by Foot

Urwagwa, the Banana Beer of Rites

THE STORY

Banana beer is ritual infrastructure — the medium of marriage negotiations, ancestral offerings and reconciliation. Named brewer Agatha Tuyisenge (Mushubati, Rutsiro), mother of five, built a livelihood from inherited brewing knowledge.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND follows one full brewing cycle toward a wedding — variety selection, foot-crushing, sorghum fermentation — and the ceremonial economy around the beer. A named protagonist with a full story arc.

Places: Mushubati · Rutsiro District · Sources: SENS Magazine (Tuyisenge profile)

The Last Sorghum Beer

Ikigage on the Volcano Slopes

THE STORY

A sorghum beer of feasts, dowries and harvests near Kinigi and Musanze, now on the Slow Food Ark of Taste — declining as sorghum is squeezed out by the Crop Intensification Programme.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND documents a household that still grows sorghum and brews ikigage for weddings — a compressed portrait of what agricultural policy does to cultural memory.

Places: Kinigi · Musanze · Sources: Slow Food Ark of Taste; Slow Food Rwanda

A Harvest Without Its Secrets

Umuganura and the Abiru

THE STORY

Umuganura was a sacred rite of ubwiru guarded by the hereditary Abiru, needing sacred sorghum from Huro (Gakenke). Abolished by the Belgians in 1925; revived in 2011 as a secular holiday — without the Abiru, the plants, or the secret language.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND shoots the intact-but-vacant ritual site at Huro against the August state festival — a ceremony hollowed of meaning and repurposed for nation-building. A story about what revival leaves out.

Places: Huro · Bumbogo · Gakenke District · Sources: ubwiru / Abiru historiography

The Morality of Milk

Kivuguto and the Inkongoro Gourd

THE STORY

Fermented milk made in handmade inkongoro gourds carrying unique indigenous microbial cultures — the moral order encoded in how milk is stored, fermented and shared, now replaced by steel tanks and controlled starters.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND builds a diptych: morning milking and gourd fermentation in a pastoral household, against a modern dairy plant making packaged ‘yogurt drinks’. Elders speak to the symbolism of the gourd.

Places: Pastoral households · Musanze / Gishwati · Sources: INLAND Rwanda research corpus

Life After the Forest*The Gishwati Resettlement*

THE STORY

Families moved off the Gishwati–Mukura forests now farm ~0.5 ha on steep, flood-prone slopes in Nyabihu, Rutsiro and Rubavu. Some, like Laurent Hategekimana, patrol as unpaid auxiliaries the forest margins their families were removed from.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND walks the forest margin with a patroller and spends time in the resettlement villages — the long, quiet afterlife of displacement on a landscape remade by ranching, floods and restoration.

Places: Nyabihu · Rutsiro · Rubavu · Bigogwe · Sources: Rainforest Journalism Fund; Pulitzer Center

Thirty Years On*The Reconciliation Coffee Cooperatives*

THE STORY

Cooperatives built post-1994 to put Hutu and Tutsi farmers in the same washing stations — Maraba (Huye) and Dukunde Kawa Musasa (Gakenke). The origin story is told; the present is unfilmed.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND follows one or two families through a harvest — picking, sorting, washing — asking quietly what changed in a generation and what didn't. The founders are middle-aged now; their children work side by side.

Places: Maraba (Huye) · Dukunde Kawa (Gakenke) · Sources: Alliance for Coffee Excellence; cooperative profiles

The Last Maestro*Vianey Mushabizi and the Inanga*

THE STORY

A single instrument and the man who may be the end of its line: Vianey Mushabizi (Gatagara), possibly the last living master of the inanga zither — the sound of a pre-radio Rwanda held in one pair of hands.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND records his repertoire and tuning, and asks the question of transmission: is there an apprentice, or does the line end here? A portrait in sound and image.

Places: Gatagara · Sources: INLAND Rwanda research corpus

Geometry of the Widows

Imigongo and the Market

THE STORY

Geometric cow-dung relief paintings made by genocide widows in Kakira, Eastern Province — now commercialised. A tension between cultural preservation, livelihood and market co-option.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND documents the making and the market in one place — who paints, who sells, who profits when a domestic craft scales into a souvenir.

Places: Kakira · Eastern Province · Sources: INLAND Rwanda research corpus

The Data Centre and the Hill

Two Relationships to Electricity

THE STORY

A windowless server warehouse runs 24 hours at full load a few kilometres from villages where electricity arrived three years ago. The guard at the gate is from such a village.

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND anchors the development showcase in one human — the guard — to portray two relationships to electricity, land and the future coexisting within a few kilometres, without abstraction.

Places: Eastern Province / peri-Kigali · Sources: INLAND Rwanda research corpus

Production Tracks

The Musanze Cluster

STORIES 01 + 03 + 05

A single northern base yields three nested stories: Batwa forest knowledge, the hospital-to-healer uburozi referral, and the last sorghum beer. One deployment, three custodian-led narratives around Musanze and Kinigi.

Geography: Musanze → Kinigi → forest margins

Season: Flexible (dry season for access)

3 stories, 1 field base

Brewing & Land

STORIES 04 + 08 (+ 07)

A western cluster binding the urwagwa brewing cycle in Rutsiro, the Gishwati resettlement in Nyabihu, and the kivuguto milk diptych. Ritual food and the afterlife of displacement on the same hillsides.

Geography: Rutsiro → Nyabihu → Rubavu

Season: Toward a wedding / harvest

2–3 stories, 1 deployment

Coffee & Memory

STORIES 09 + 06 (+ 11)

A southern/eastern cluster: the reconciliation coffee cooperatives thirty years on, the hollowed Umuganura harvest at Huro, and the imigongo widows. Memory, harvest and craft across Huye, Gakenke and the East.

Geography: Huye → Gakenke → Eastern Province

Season: Coffee harvest; August (Umuganura)

2–3 stories, seasonal windows

The Partnership

EUROPEAN PARTNER

INLAND — yearly publication (Italy / EU). Editorial, photography and publishing; presentation of the work in Europe.

AFRICAN PARTNER

A Rwandan cultural organisation (lead candidate: Red Rocks Initiatives, Musanze) — co-creation, community access, custodian liaison, presentation in Rwanda.

FUNDING PATH

Mobility grant (≤€4,000) funds the scouting trip; the Visual Arts grant funds collaborative production and a public presentation in Rwanda and Europe.

THE PRINCIPLE

Made with custodians, not about them — equitable Africa–Europe co-creation, exactly the dialogue the Goethe programme exists to fund.